

The Bloodtooth

In the dark of night, there was no noise in the fortress, save for one. No feasts were held in these halls, no drunken men chanted war songs or reminisced the days of old, for the air was thick with the grim weight of an oncoming battle. And yet, an aria of blade on wood radiated throughout the impenetrable void of darkness, piercing the solemn mood of a castle preparing for conflict. All knew that only one man could cause such a serenade with the sword: Royce the Bloodtooth was the only lord determined enough to be training so late the night before a paramount battle.

Royce of House Aurelis swiftly lunged forward, rending the head of yet another training dummy with an arcing slash. Straw and wood piled in the corner of the training field, vestiges of those had felled from his toils through the night. Swiping a bead of sweat from his face, he noticed the moonlight shimmer off the tip of his crimson sword, a heirloom of the royal family from which he inherited. The sword was one with him, still weightless in his grip despite the many hours he had been honing his skills that night. Word passed down for generations within the royal line said that this sword was once a silver blade, but its intransigent bloodlust had stained its sheen red over the decades. Allies, enemies, and even the commoners had come up with names for this blade, but Royce merely laughed at this blasphemy. “A blade needs no name,” he would say, “For the dead cannot speak. Let the blood spilled upon this blade be portent to my power, to both the gods above and the damned below.”

The only figure more venerated than his sword was Royce himself, monikered the Bloodtooth for his aura of immortality on the battlefield. Royce was blessed with swordplay skills few could ever hope to rival, and the power of the royal army backing him. It was his

responsibility to protect the Aurelis Kingdom, as he was the crown prince, set to inherit the throne from his lord father one day.

As he continued his strife against the dummies, Royce's mind flashed back to the times he was trained by his elder master-at-arms as a budding knight, the only man who had impressed him in terms of wisdom and skill in his life.

"Your blows have strength, yes, and skill, boy," the grizzled veteran had said years ago as their swords darted at each other, "but you have no impetus behind them. The knight who strikes with no love or ire will soon fall, but no steel in this world can match the resolve of a man with a singular purpose in mind." A devastating stab was sent at his plated chest, the jolting blow knocking him off his feet in an instant. Royce felt the echoing scars of his master's precise sword decades after that era. "I survived twenty campaigns to secure this Kingdom's prosperity. If you believe my skill alone won this throne, you must think again," he asserted, leaving Royce dazed on the floor, his mythical sword reduced to a twig in the face of his master's undaunted willpower.

Royce faltered at this memory, the stoic knight realizing why the rival army had routed his legions twice now: they ran on pure camaraderie and a lust for destruction against the dominant Kingdom of Aurelis. They had come to understand the power of resolve and vengeance, a lesson in human empathy that Royce had yet to harmonize with. In comparison, Royce had relied on his raw finesse for swordsmanship and his affinity for battle to conquer wars, having not the emotional attachments others did. He merely fought out of duty for the title and prestige he had been born into. The Aurelis Kingdom had not known defeat for years under the leadership of Royce and his predecessors, yet this enemy had given them the bitter taste of

loss on distant fields and was set to invade the kingdom on the morrow. This time, defeat would be permanent were it to happen.

The cobblestones of the castle softly rumbled under the weight of Royce's silvered mail, treading back to his quarters as he recalled the wisdoms of his bygone master. Royce was a godless man and one of few words, preferring to let his sword speak for him. He believed a parley was the purest of conversations: two swords begin a dance, and the truest emerges the victor. He had no fellowship with his men, only seeing them as tools for conquest.

As he entered his quarters, his wife slept softly on the bed as the embers of a fire faded within the hearth, dimming like a dragon's fire into the maw of a night sky. Similar to his men, he had little love for his wife, marrying her out of duty in a betrothal rather than for love. In the corner of the room, his son cooed from his wood-weaved crib. Born scarce a fortnight ago, Royce had not even minutes to interact with his son over the past days due to the dire preparations taking place for the clash. Royce went over and peered into the cradle, seeing his son gently rustled by the noise of his entry. His son playfully pawed at the air towards his father, with all of the purity of a clean flame. As Royce looked into the deep azure eyes of his son, a realization dawned over him: were he to suffer defeat in the next battle, he would lose his son. He would lose everything. His master's words echoed in his head: *No steel in this world can match the resolve of a man with a singular purpose in mind.*

Royce had never cared much for life, watching it slowly drain from the eyes of his slain foes like the embers of the waning flame adjacent to him. After all, he had been born a scion of the highest family and was groomed for perfection. All people were merely a tool or obstacle towards his succession. Chess pieces upon his grand board. Yet, only now he realized the precious innocence of his son, who would later inherit his title as king after the gods took Royce.

Rather than looking upon the visage of Death in his felled opponents, Royce witnessed the splendor of life in his son. The cerulean hue of his son's eyes meeting his own gaze seemed to phase his soul from his body, and he perceived the infinite wonders of a life he had never experienced: a resplendent ocean, crested by the glistening inferno of the sun. A verdant field, host to a chromatic mosaic of flowers peacefully folding under a gentle breeze. A family comforted by their love borne for one another, safe within the stone walls of the home they built together.

He had realized the beauty of life, this fleeting gift he had never cared to look for, and that this was the true meaning of what he must protect. This applied to every man in his battalion, too; they all had a mother and wife praying for their safe return, a son awaiting the patient strength of a father to guide them. Defeat meant the death of himself, the Aurelis Kingdom, his son, his men. He had never come upon this revelation, drunk on the intoxicating draught of victory and suffering defeat so little in his lifetime. For the first time, Royce felt a deep resonance from within his core, and he experienced a new feeling: fear. Inspiration. "I will give you the world, my son," he vowed, choking on the words as he reached down and delicately carressed the babe's soft skin, his cold mailed hand feeling the warmth of love for the first time. They said the Bloodtooth never cried, but Royce felt tears stinging at his eyes as this newly found resolve washed over him.

The flags of the Aurelis Kingdom whispered in the wind as the sun crested over a sprawling field. Inscribed upon these black flags was the insignia of Aurelis: a golden sun severed by a red blade, the very same carried by Royce. An omen, he hoped, that his enemies would be razed asunder just as easily. Ethereal mists wisped through the air like the omnipotent fingers of Death itself, playfully curling around the battle-ready men, as if mocking their petty

battles and inevitable future. Thousands of cavalry and infantry lined up on this hallowed clearing, awaiting their foreboding fate with no protest. Across from the flags, the enemy host mirrored them, solemnly acknowledging the blood-slicked contract they had signed with their destiny in the name of conquest and glory. Royce's deep crimson sword gleamed like a conflagration in the waking sunlight, and he silently assessed his men from atop his gilded destrier. The only thing audible was the soft rattle of his steel as his mount gallantly sauntered through the ranks of the battalion. To the shock of all his men, he began a speech.

"I may not have cared for much but my throne in the past, but I am a changed man. I now see the valor in all of you, the unending loyalty you have pledged and bled for under the flag of Aurelis. I acknowledge your sacrifice, my brave men. We shall not suffer another defeat to these usurpers. I fight for you. I fight for the emblem of Aurelis, and all of the sacred lives within we must protect!"

Royce pondered whether his vulnerability would be accepted after so many years of donning a facade of stoicism, as a silence even deadlier than before hung among them. Could they see past his reputation of being a blood-stained deity in battle, and understand the renewed man within? Doubtful thoughts consumed his mind, as he imagined losing the loyalty of his men and therefore the battle. Would he dishonor the covenant he had made with his son so quickly? The tendrils of mist seemed to intensify around him, as if Death itself were closing in on his doomed soul...

Suddenly, the metallic *schwing* of a sword being unsheathed shattered his worrisome thoughts, as a soldier pointed his steel at Royce and took a knee. Others did the same, and soon the entire battalion rallied around him, swords rising in motion and lances slamming into the ground in rhythm with an encore of shouts: "Bloodtooth! Bloodtooth!" Royce smiled with pride,

feeling the empowerment of having a kindred bond with his men for the first time. “Good,” he laughed. “Let us smite these enemies from our home!” Upon hearing these words, his men released a roar of fervor, awakened for the most important battle of their lives.

A triumphant war horn blared from the side of Aurelis; the enemy matched it with their own. The armies began a deafening charge, Royce leading the way with his blade outstretched. As he watched his men plunge into battle on his side, he reveled in the aura of trust and camaraderie that he had lacked for all this time, and vowed to match their resolute wills. He would not let his kingdom fall, powered by his love for his son. Today, his scarlet sword would drink deeply on the crimson tides to come.